

KOREAN BBQ

고기구이 — The Table Grill as Stage

Table Grill Service

House Kimchi

28 Menu Items



Korean BBQ is not a meal, it is an event. The table grill is a stage, the banchan are the opening act, and the meat is the performance — which means the operator is running a theatre as much as a kitchen. This guide builds a 40-seat room with 28 items: banchan made in house, fermentation treated as an asset that appreciates, every formula in grams, and the service standard that decides everything, which Koreans call nunchi — the ability to read a table before it asks.

28

menu items

40

seats

22%

blended cost

\$55–80

per head

Kimchi, Jang and Dashi

Three things underpin this menu and all three are time rather than money: house kimchi, properly aged jang, and anchovy-kelp dashi. Every stew, every banchan and half the sauces come out of them, and unlike most kitchens' base preps, these get better the longer the restaurant is open.

House Kimchi

Baechu kimchi (per 5kg napa): napa cabbage 5,000g · coarse salt for brining 500g (10%) · gochugaru 250g (5%) · fish sauce 150ml (3%) · garlic 120g · ginger 50g · daikon, julienned 800g · spring onion 200g · glutinous rice porridge 400g · sugar 40g. Brine 4–6 hours, ferment 3 days at 18–20°C, then 2°C.

Brine at 10% of the cabbage weight for four to six hours until a thick leaf-stem bends without snapping — that is the doneness cue, not the clock, since cabbage water content varies by season. Rinse three times and drain hard. The rice porridge is the detail most home recipes skip and it matters: its starch feeds the lactic bacteria and gives the paste something to cling to, so the fermentation starts fast and evenly. Three days at ambient takes the pH from about 6.2 to **4.2–4.5**, at which point it goes into the cold and slows to a crawl. Then taste it daily and understand that you now have two products from one crock: *geotjeori*, fresh and crunchy and bright, and *mukimchi*, weeks older, sour and funky and structurally softer. Both belong on the table, and the old sour stuff is not waste — it is the required ingredient for kimchi jjigae, which means **the restaurant's stew improves every month it stays open**.

Dashi, Jang and Sauces

Anchovy-kelp dashi (per 5L): dried anchovies, heads and guts removed 100g (2%) · dried kelp 40g · dried shiitake 30g · onion 200g · water 5L. Steep kelp at 60–70°C, remove before boil; simmer anchovy 15 min, strain. Ssamjang (1kg): doenjang 600g (60%) · gochujang 250g (25%) · sesame oil 60ml · toasted sesame 40g · garlic 40g · spring onion 60g · sugar 30g · rice syrup 40g.

Bulgogi marinade (per 5kg beef): soy 750ml (15%) · grated Korean pear 1,000g (20%) · sugar 250g · sesame oil 150ml · garlic 150g · ginger 60g · black pepper 15g · mirin 150ml.

Galbi marinade: as bulgogi with pear raised to 25% and mirin to 200ml. Marinate 12–24 hours.

Dashi is the base of every stew here and it has one rule: **the kelp comes out before the water boils**. Above about 70°C kelp releases alginates that turn the stock slimy and faintly bitter, so it steeps low and is lifted before the anchovies go in for their fifteen minutes. Doenjang and gochujang are both living, aged pastes, and the aged doenjang at two to three years is worth the premium — it is darker, deeper and more pungent than young paste, and Japanese miso is not a substitute in either direction. The marinades run on **grated Korean pear at 20–25%**, which is a working enzyme rather than a sweetener: its proteases cut the muscle fibres and produce the almost-melting texture bulgogi is known for. That also sets a hard limit — beyond 12 hours for thin bulgogi and 24 for short rib, the enzymes go too far and the meat turns mushy and pasty in a way no cooking recovers.

DEFECT	CAUSE	CORRECTION
Dashi slimy and bitter	Kelp boiled rather than steeped	Steep at 60–70°C and remove before the boil

DEFECT	CAUSE	CORRECTION
Bulgogi mushy	Marinated past 12 hours in 20% pear	2–12 hours for thin cuts; 24 max for galbi
Bulgogi grey and boiled	Cooked on medium in its own liquid	Very high heat, small batches, caramelised edges
Doenjang jjigae bitter	Paste boiled after incorporation	Whisk in off direct heat; simmer gently only
Kimchi jjigae thin and flat	Fresh kimchi used instead of aged	Mukimchi, 2+ weeks, plus its juice
Pajeon chewy, not crisp	Batter over-mixed or not ice-cold	50/50 rice flour, ice water, lumps left in
Acrid smoke on grilled meat	Carbonised fat on the grate	Swap the grate every 2–3 orders

The Opening Act — Nos. 01–06

01 — Banchan Set (six dishes · complimentary)

\$2.24 cost per table

Per table of four: baechu kimchi 80g · japchae 60g · sigeumchi namul 50g · kongnamul 50g · danmuji 40g · dubu jorim 60g · ganjang 20ml · ssamjang 30g.

Banchan are complimentary and they are not free — at \$2.24 a table they are the best-spent marketing money in the building, because a table that sits down to eight small bowls already feels fed and looked after before a single order is placed. Two technical rules carry the whole set. Namul are blanched and then **seasoned assertively** — sesame oil, garlic, soy, toasted seed — because they are competing with charred fatty meat and an under-seasoned namul simply disappears from the table. And japchae is built by cooking every component separately and combining at the end: spinach blanched 30 seconds and wrung dry, carrot stir-fried two minutes, mushroom sautéed to gold, noodles dressed warm so they absorb, then folded together with hands or tongs rather than stirred. Cooked together it goes grey and homogeneous. Then the service rule that is really the whole philosophy: **refill an empty bowl before the guest notices it is empty**. Asking is acceptable. Silently replacing is the standard to train for.



02 — Haemul Pajeon (seafood spring onion pancake)

\$14.99 · FC 12.3%

Per pancake: plain flour 75g and rice flour 75g (50/50) · ice water 170ml · egg 1 · whole spring onions 6 stalks / 80g · squid rings 50g · prawn 40g · ganjang dip 40ml. High heat, 4 min then 3 min.

Rice flour at half the total is what makes this shatter rather than bend — it has no gluten to develop and it fries to a brittle lattice. Use genuinely **ice-cold water** and mix minimally, lumps and all: an over-mixed batter builds gluten and gives a doughy, chewy pancake, which is the single commonest pajeon failure. Lay the spring onions lengthwise across the oiled pan first so they show through the finished pancake, pour the batter over, and press the seafood into the top. Then the discipline: **four minutes without touching it**, because the bottom crust only forms if the

pancake is left alone, and it is ready to turn when it slides freely. One confident flip with two spatulas, three minutes on the second side. Cut into six or eight wedges and send immediately — steam from the seafood migrates into the crust and softens it within five minutes, so the guest should be told to eat it hot.



03 — Tteokbokki (spicy rice cakes)

\$11.99 · FC 15.5%

Per serve: garae-tteok rice cakes 180g · gochujang 40g · gochugaru 5g · eomuk fish cake 60g · anchovy-kelp dashi 200ml · sugar and soy 15g · spring onion, sesame, boiled egg 20g. Simmer 8–10 min.

The base ratio is three parts gochujang to one part gochugaru per 200ml of dashi, and the dashi is not optional — built on water instead of anchovy-kelp stock the sauce is flatly spicy with no savoury floor under it, which is exactly the difference between tteokbokki that tastes Korean and tteokbokki that tastes like chilli paste. Frozen rice cakes need **30 minutes in cold water** before they go anywhere near heat, or they stay hard in the middle however long they simmer. Eight to ten minutes in the sauce, during which they plump and take on gloss and the sauce thickens around them; the finished cake should be chewy right through with no chalky centre and not a moment past that, since overcooked tteok goes slack and loses the springiness that is the whole point. Serve bubbling in a stone pot or small cast iron, and offer mild, medium and hot at the order — Korean hot is genuinely hot and saying so prevents complaints.



04 — Japchae (entrée portion · vegan)

\$13.99 · FC 10.8%

Per serve: dangmyeon sweet potato noodles 100g dry · shiitake 60g · spinach 50g · carrot 40g · onion 40g · soy, sesame oil, sugar, garlic 30ml · toasted sesame and spring onion 5g.

Boil the dangmyeon six to eight minutes until fully translucent with a slight chew, rinse cold, and drain **completely** — residual water dilutes the seasoning and produces watery japchae that never recovers. Dress the noodles while still warm, because warm starch takes up soy and sesame far more readily than cold. Every vegetable is cooked and seasoned separately for the reason described above, then everything is folded together gently rather than stirred, since vigorous mixing breaks the noodles and mashes the vegetables into one texture. The finished dish should look glossy from the sesame oil, which is the visual signal that it is properly seasoned. Good warm, at room temperature or lightly chilled, which is rare on this menu. Add bulgogi strips for a \$4 upcharge that costs almost nothing.

05 — Sundubu Jjigae (soft tofu stew · egg cracked tableside)

\$15.99 · FC 20.3%

Per dolsot: extra-soft silken tofu 200g · clams 80g · prawn 40g · anchovy-kelp dashi 250ml · gochugaru, gochujang, garlic, sesame oil 20g · egg 1 · steamed rice 180g.

The stone pot is the equipment and the method. Heat the dolsot empty until it smokes, then **bloom the gochugaru in sesame oil directly in the hot pot** — capsanthin and the aromatic compounds are fat-soluble, so a few seconds in hot oil produces the brilliant red and the deep chilli flavour that stirring powder into liquid never gives you. Garlic, seafood, dashi, then the tofu added in large torn spoonfuls straight from the tube: never sliced, never diced, and **never stirred**, because agitation collapses it and the whole presentation depends on those big trembling pieces. Two to three minutes and it is just set. The pot goes to the table still at a violent boil and the egg is cracked into the centre in front of the guest, where residual heat brings it to jammy in about two minutes. Tell them that, then leave it.

06 — Dakgangjeong (crispy glazed chicken)

\$13.99 · FC 13.1%

Per serve: boneless chicken thigh in bite cubes 160g · potato starch coating 30g · glaze of soy, gochujang, honey, garlic, ginger and rice vinegar 50ml · crushed peanuts 15g · sesame, red chilli, spring onion. First fry 160°C for 4 min, rest 3 min, second fry 190°C for 90 sec.

Potato starch rather than flour, because it fries to a glassier, more brittle shell that survives being sauced. The double fry works on a specific mechanism: the first pass at 160°C cooks the chicken through without colouring it, the three-minute rest lets internal moisture migrate to the surface, and the second pass at 190°C flashes that moisture to steam which puffs the crust from underneath while setting it hard. Then the glaze, reduced to a pourable syrup, tossed onto the chicken **straight out of the fryer** so residual heat caramelises the sugars on contact — thirty seconds of constant tossing, then plated. Peanuts go on *after* glazing, never into it, where they would absorb moisture and go soft. That one detail is the difference between technically executed dakgangjeong and a mediocre version.



The Grill and the Kitchen — Nos. 07–16

The menu splits deliberately. Table-grilled proteins drive engagement and spend; kitchen dishes serve guests who do not want to grill, add variety to a shared table, and relieve grill congestion at peak. A room built only on grill items bottlenecks at eight o'clock on a Saturday.

07 — Samgyeopsal (thick-cut pork belly · table grill)

\$24.99 · FC 16.0%

Per serve: skin-on pork belly sliced 1.5–2cm 200g · perilla and butter lettuce, 8 leaves each · ssamjang 30g · aged kimchi for grilling 60g · whole garlic 6 cloves · sesame oil and salt dish 10ml. 7–8 min on the grill.

Pork belly is the most-ordered item in Korean BBQ globally and the specification is narrow: skin-on, consistent fat-to-meat ratio, cut **1.5 to 2cm thick** — thick enough to survive seven or eight minutes of grilling with rendered fat and a crisp exterior, thin enough to cook through in that window. No marinade, because the point is the pork. Then the technique most US kitchens miss: **put aged kimchi on the grill alongside for the last three minutes.** It caramelises, loses its raw fermented edge and turns sweet-savoury, and grilled pork fat with caramelised kimchi is one of the great pairings in the cuisine. Cut with dedicated kitchen scissors at the table, which is standard practice and gives a cleaner cut on a hot grate than any knife. Offer both dips — ssamjang and sesame oil with flaked salt. At the end, scrape the rendered fat and caramelised scraps together with the last of the kimchi and eat it with rice; teach that move to first-timers, because it is what regulars do automatically.

Why it carries the P&L. At 16% food cost and roughly \$21 contribution it is the most profitable BBQ item by volume, and nearly every table orders it. An ibérico upgrade at \$34.99 adds about \$8 of margin for a small cost difference and sells itself on the marbling.

08 — Chadolbaegi (paper-thin brisket · table grill)

\$28.99 · FC 18.5%

Per serve: beef brisket sliced 1–2mm 200g · perilla and lettuce 8 leaves each · ssamjang 30g · whole garlic 6 · green chilli and spring onion 10g · sesame oil and salt 10ml. 60–90 seconds on the grill.

The slicing *is* the product. Brisket comes off the slicer at **1 to 2mm**, which means the block is partially frozen for two hours first — at that thickness it curls and caramelises in sixty to ninety seconds and stays juicy. Cut thicker it needs real cooking time, dries out, and the dish loses its reason to exist. Teach the ssam at the table: perilla or lettuce, a piece of brisket, a little ssamjang, a grilled garlic clove, green chilli if wanted, folded and eaten in one bite. That one hospitality moment is what guests recount afterwards. And one rule sits behind every grill item — brisket renders heavily and the fat carbonises, so **swap the grate every two to three orders**, because burnt fat makes acrid smoke that flavours everything cooked after it. Pre-heat spare grates before service so the swap is invisible.



09 — Galbi (LA-cut short rib · the premium anchor)

\$34.99 · FC 24.2%

Per serve: flanken-cut beef short rib 250g · galbi marinade 80ml with pear at 25%, 12–24 hours · ssam wraps 6 leaves each · ssamjang and sesame salt. Grill 3–4 min a side.

The LA cut — flanken, sliced across the bones so each strip carries three or four small bone cross-sections — was developed in the Korean community in Los Angeles and is now the classic preparation. Most standard butchers need it specially ordered, and finding one who understands it is part of opening. Short rib carries more connective tissue than brisket or belly, so it needs the **full 12 to 24 hours** in the marinade; under twelve tastes underdeveloped, and marinating 48 hours ahead is a legitimate schedule because the flavour keeps deepening. On the grill the bone sections act as heat sinks, so the meat nearest them cooks slower — three to four minutes a side gives caramelised, faintly charred edges, a blush of pink and fat fully rendered around the bone. Cut between the bones with scissors so each piece is one mouthful. Never discount galbi; the price is part of what it communicates.



10 — Bulgogi (grill or stone bowl)

\$29.99 · FC 19.7%

Per serve: ribeye or sirloin sliced 3–4mm 200g · bulgogi marinade 60ml, 2–12 hours · onion 40g · spring onion and sesame 10g · steamed rice 180g.

Grated Korean pear at 20% of the marinade is enzymatic rather than culinary — its proteases cut muscle fibre over two to four hours and produce the tender, almost-melting texture that defines bulgogi and that no cooking method reproduces. Twelve hours is the ceiling. On the heat the rule is **very high and very fast**: the sugar in the marinade caramelises in two to three minutes on a screaming grill or cast iron, giving glossy edges and a pink interior. The failure is cooking it on medium in its own liquid, which boils the beef grey and textureless — small batches, hot surface, no crowding. Offer it either at the table or kitchen-fired in a hot stone bowl, which on a busy Saturday relieves the grills with no drop in quality, and ask the guest which they want.

11 — Dak Galbi (spicy chicken skillet for two · cheese +\$3)

\$22.99 · FC 15.8%

Per serve for two: boneless chicken thigh 250g · gochujang marinade 60g, 4+ hours · garae-tteok 100g · napa cabbage, sweet potato, onion, spring onion 150g · perilla 6 leaves · mozzarella option 60g.

Four hours minimum in the marinade, which gets flavour into the thigh rather than onto it and helps it caramelize. Cooked on a flat cast-iron skillet over a table burner, which is how Chuncheon does it, and the additions are **timed rather than dumped**: chicken three minutes, vegetables two, rice cakes three, perilla at the very end so it wilts without blackening. Everything at once leaves the sweet potato raw while the chicken overcooks. Offer regular and spicy honestly, because Korean spicy is genuinely hot. And offer the mozzarella — cheese dak galbi is a real trend and the stretch out of a red skillet is the most shared image this menu produces, so build the \$3 into the cost expectation rather than resisting it.

12 — Kimchi Jjigae (aged kimchi and pork belly)

\$15.99 · FC 17.3%

Per dolsot: mukimchi, 2+ weeks fermented 150g · pork belly in 2cm cubes 100g · firm tofu 100g · anchovy-kelp dashi 250ml · kimchi juice 40ml · gochugaru, garlic, sesame oil 15g · rice 180g. Simmer 20 min minimum.

This dish requires **over-fermented kimchi** — the intensely sour, funky kimchi that would be unpleasant as a side dish becomes magnificent under heat, which is why Korean kitchens deliberately rotate the oldest crock into the stew rather than discarding it. Render the pork belly first in a dry pot for four or five minutes until the fat releases and the edges colour, then cook the kimchi and aromatics *in that rendered fat*, which builds depth that adding pork and liquid together cannot. Deglaze with the kimchi juice, which is concentrated fermentation and never poured away. Then twenty minutes minimum, because a rushed jjigae tastes harsh and disjointed where a properly simmered one is unified. Tofu in the last five minutes only. Served bubbling with plain rice, since the contrast of unseasoned rice against that broth is how it is eaten.



13 — Doenjang Jjigae

\$14.99 · FC 12.0%

Per dolsot: aged doenjang, 2–3 years 45g · firm tofu 100g · courgette 60g · shiitake 40g · anchovy-kelp dashi 300ml · onion, garlic, green chilli 30g · rice 180g.

The paste is the dish, so buy aged doenjang and do not substitute Japanese miso — it is a longer, deeper, more pungent ferment and Korean guests identify the swap instantly. Then the one rule: **never boil it**. Doenjang carries live cultures and volatile aromatics that heat destroys, so the build is garlic in sesame oil, dashi to a gentle simmer, vegetables and tofu in, and the paste whisked in *off direct heat*, after which it simmers gently and never rolls. The bitterness guests sometimes complain about in restaurant doenjang jjigae is boiling, every time. Served in a hot stone pot still simmering at the table so the guest eats progressively as it cools — that slow cooling is part of it, and a cold bowl signals a kitchen that does not know the dish. At 12% it is the best-margin kitchen main and the one Korean guests judge hardest.

14 — Dolsot Bibimbap

\$17.99 · FC 12.2%

Per dolsot: short-grain rice 200g cooked · seasoned beef mince 80g · five namul — spinach, bean sprout, carrot, mushroom, courgette 150g combined · fried egg 1 · gochujang 25g tableside · sesame oil, sesame seed, nori.

Heat the stone pot until it smokes, add sesame oil, then the rice, which hisses aggressively — press it gently against the sides and leave it, because what forms underneath is *nurungji*, the golden crust that is the entire reason to pay three dollars more for the *dolsot* version, and the guest scrapes it up as they mix. The five **namul** are arranged in **separate wedges like spokes**, equal portions, distinct colours: that arrangement communicates balance and is the classical presentation, where a haphazard pile signals indifference. Gochujang arrives on top unmixed or in a separate dish and is never stirred through in the kitchen — mixing is the guest's ritual and their heat control, and taking it away removes their agency. Tell first-timers to mix everything and that the heat is up to them.



15 — Naengmyeon (cold buckwheat noodles)

\$16.99 · FC 16.4%

Per serve: naengmyeon noodles 130g dry · dongchimi broth at 2°C 300ml, over ice · boiled chilled brisket 60g · cucumber, pickled radish, pear 80g · half a boiled egg · Korean mustard and rice vinegar tableside.

Cold buckwheat noodles in an icy, mildly sour radish-kimchi broth after an hour of rich smoky meat is one of the great progressions in any cuisine, and temperature is the technique: the broth is held at **2°C and served over ice**, almost uncomfortably cold, because that shock against heat and fat is the point. A tepid naengmyeon is simply wrong. Noodles boiled three to four minutes, rinsed hard in ice water until genuinely cold, drained completely — they are famously chewy and resistant, which is why scissors go to the table with them. Mustard and vinegar are added by the guest to adjust heat and sourness, and Korean mustard is much stronger than Western, which is worth saying. Train the floor to offer it toward the end of the grill courses, when guests hit richness fatigue; conversion is very high.

16 — Galbi Jjim (braised short rib · weekend only)

\$29.99 · FC 23.2%

Per serve: English-cut bone-in short rib 300g raw · braise of soy, pear juice, sesame oil, garlic, ginger, mirin and sugar 300ml · daikon 80g · carrot 60g · shiitake 40g · rice, spring onion, pine nuts. 150°C for 2.5 hours.

Blanch first, always: cover the ribs in cold water, bring to the boil, throw that grey scum-filled water away and rinse. It removes blood and bone fragments that would cloud the braise and leave a harsh edge, and every galbi jjim that tastes slightly off was made without it. Then **150°C, covered, two and a half hours**, until the collagen has converted, the liquid has reduced to a glaze and the meat falls from the bone while holding its shape. Daikon and carrot in for the final 45 minutes so they absorb the braise without collapsing; mushrooms in the last twenty. Braise ten or twelve portions on Thursday or Friday and refrigerate overnight — the fat sets and lifts off cleanly and the flavour deepens measurably — then reheat to order in eight minutes. Run it as a weekend special and let it sell out.

Ice, Honey and Rice — Nos. 17–20

17 — Bingsu (milk shaved ice)

\$11.99 · FC 14.1%

Per serve: frozen milk block, shaved 250g · sweetened red bean paste 80g · mochi 40g · condensed milk 20ml · seasonal fruit 60g · injeolmi powder 10g optional.

Milk ice, not water ice — freeze lightly sweetened full-fat milk in 500ml blocks and shave from frozen, which gives a soft snow-like texture where water ice gives chips and slush. That difference is the dish, and it needs a real shaved-ice machine rather than a blender. Build for **height**: a mound rising eight to ten centimetres above the rim, then red bean, mochi, condensed milk and fruit, because a flat sparse bingsu cannot justify \$11.99 and a towering one obviously can. It starts melting the moment it leaves the machine, so it is made live and on the table within three minutes, and the guest is told to eat it quickly — that urgency is authentic to how it is sold on the street. Seasonal fruit gives the menu a reason to change.



18 — Hotteok (2 pancakes · molten brown sugar)

\$7.99 · FC 9.3%

Per serve: yeasted dough 120g (flour, instant yeast, sugar, warm milk, salt) rested 1 hour · filling of dark brown sugar, cinnamon and crushed walnut 30g · vanilla ice cream 60g · sesame. Pressed and fried 3 min then 2 min.

The hour of rest is the recipe: yeast fermentation gives hotteok its slightly chewy, faintly tangy interior, and under-rested dough fries into a dense flat pancake with none of that character. Portion at 60g, flatten in the palm, 15g of filling in the centre, then **seal completely** — any gap lets the sugar escape, where it burns on the pan and the pancake loses its molten centre. Press flat to about 8mm with a hotteok press or a wide spatula the moment it hits the oiled pan, three minutes to deep gold, flip, press again, two more minutes. The filling liquefies entirely, so the interior is genuinely molten when bitten, which most guests have no reference point for. With vanilla ice cream the hot-cold contrast is the whole pleasure, and most tables order two.

19 — Sikhye (sweet rice punch)

\$5.99 · FC 7.8%

Per serve: sikhye 250ml (malt water, cooked rice, ginger, sugar) · pine nuts 3 · jujube slice · ice.

A mildly sweet, lightly fermented rice punch served ice cold as a digestive — the amylase in malt water partially converts the rice starch to sugar, which is why it tastes sweet with little added sugar and why cooked grains float in the glass. One of the oldest drinks in the Korean repertoire and the traditional way a meal ends. Three pine nuts floated on top is the standard presentation and they add a faint nuttiness as the guest drinks. A good commercial version from a Korean grocer is entirely acceptable. At 7.8% cost it is the highest-margin item on the menu, and the line that sells it is simply true: in Korea, meals end with sikhye.

20 — Yakgwa (honey ginger cookies with tea)

\$8.99 · FC 7.5%

Per serve: yakgwa 4 cookies / 80g (flour, sesame oil, honey, ginger juice, cinnamon, a little soju) · honey syrup soak · Korean green or barley tea 200ml · pine nut garnish. Fry 150°C for 6–8 min, soak 30 min.

The dough is bound with sesame oil and honey rather than butter, and the splash of soju is functional — alcohol inhibits gluten development and evaporates in the fryer, leaving a shorter, flakier crumb. Fried slowly at **150°C for six to eight minutes**, because the sugar and honey already in the dough scorch at any higher temperature, then **soaked in warm honey-ginger syrup for thirty minutes**, which is the non-negotiable step that turns a fried biscuit into something moist, fragrant and dense. They keep a week airtight and genuinely improve over it, so make them Monday for Friday — the same principle as the kimchi. Served with boricha or nokcha, whose slight bitterness balances the honey, as the ceremonial close of the meal.

Soju, Makgeolli and the Pour — Nos. 21–28

Drinking is part of the format rather than an add-on: soju arrives with the meat and gets replaced through the evening, which is why beverage attach at a Korean BBQ table runs higher than almost any other cuisine. Two pieces of etiquette are worth training because guests love being taught them — never pour your own glass, and hold the bottle two-handed when pouring for someone older.

21 — SOJU · \$6.99 SHOT / \$18.99 BOTTLE · FC 18%

Chilled Jinro or Chamisul at 16.9% ABV in small glasses, bottle in an ice bucket. The volume driver of the whole list. Train the etiquette: the youngest pours, nobody fills their own glass, and the bottle is held two-handed for an elder. Guests taught this are delighted by it and order another bottle to keep practising.

22 — SOMAEK · \$9.99

Soju and lager built in the glass at roughly 30% soju to 70% beer — the ratio is argued about permanently and the argument is part of the fun. Lighter and more drinkable than soju alone, and it stands up to fatty grilled pork better than either component separately. Mixed at the table in front of the guest; it takes ten seconds and it is a performance.

23 — MAKGEOLLI · \$14.99 CARAFE

Unfiltered rice wine, cloudy and lightly sparkling at 6–8% ABV, served in a brass kettle with shallow bowls. Living and unpasteurised, so it is **swirled gently rather than shaken** to redistribute the sediment, and it changes character over a few days once opened. Serve very cold. The traditional partner for pajeon, which is worth mentioning when both are on the ticket.

24 — KOREAN LAGER · \$6.99

Terra or Cass, genuinely cold in a chilled glass. Light, dry and carbonated, engineered to reset the palate between bites of pork fat and gochujang. It doubles as the base for somaek, so the stock works twice. Two brands is enough — the beer list should not compete with the soju.

25 — YUJA ADE · \$5.99

Yuja-cheong, the Korean citron preserve, spooned into a tall glass with ice and topped with soda — 40g of preserve to 200ml, stirred so rind stays suspended. Fragrant, tart and faintly bitter, and the best non-alcoholic option against heat. Guests who know yuja tea are pleased to find it cold.

26 — MAESIL-CHA · \$5.49

Green plum syrup, made by layering unripe maesil with an equal weight of sugar for 100 days and drawing off the liquid, then diluted with cold water or soda. Sour, floral and traditionally digestive, which is what a table wants after an hour of grilled meat. One batch lasts a year, so the only real cost is patience.

27 — BORICHA · \$3.49

Roasted barley tea brewed strong and served hot or ice cold in a carafe on the table, refilled without being asked. Toasty, faintly bitter, caffeine-free, and what Korean households drink instead of water. Putting it on every table for almost nothing is a hospitality signal far out of proportion to its cost.

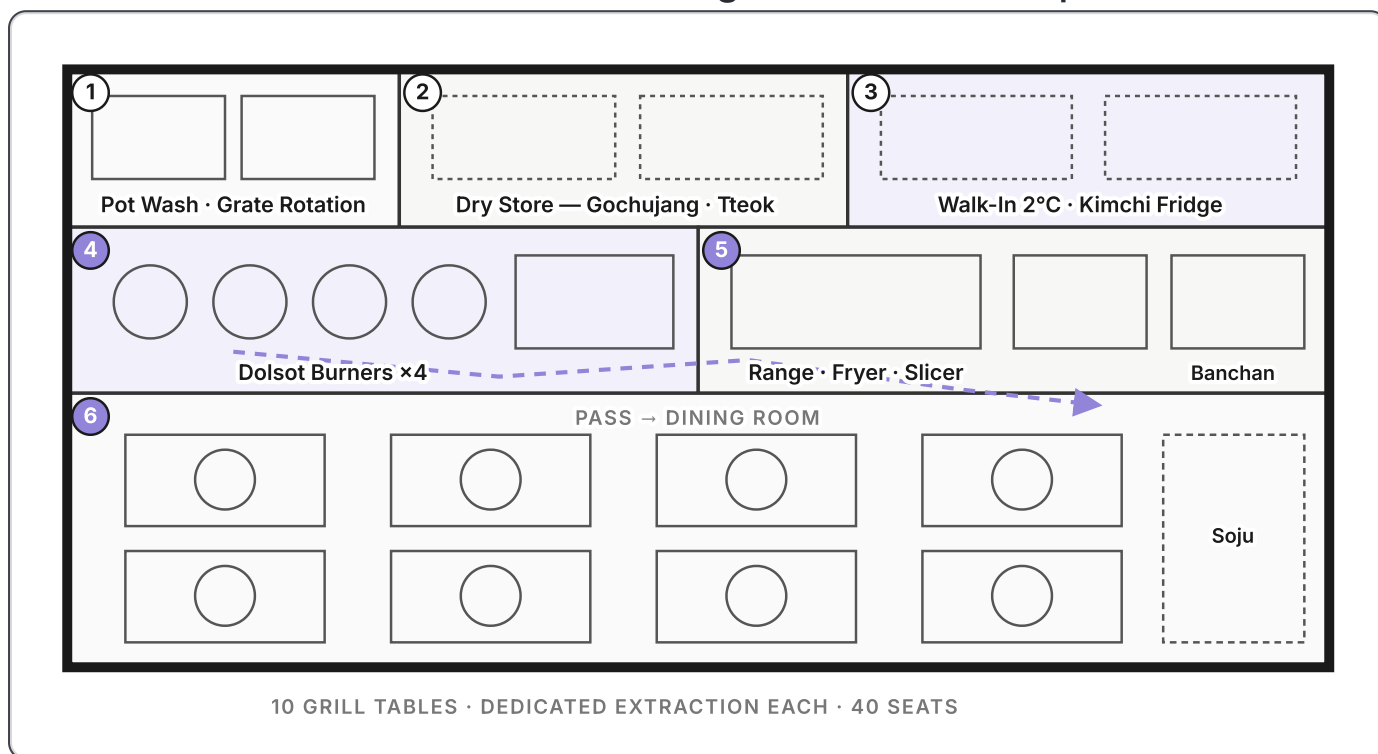
28 — WATERMELON SOJU · \$24.99

A hollowed half watermelon, flesh blended with soju and a little sugar and poured back into the shell over ice with two straws. Around 800ml for a table, the most photographed thing on the list, and genuinely seasonal — run it in summer and take it off rather than faking it with juice in February.

Extraction Is the Building

This is the only format in the series where the most expensive equipment sits in the dining room. Every table needs a grill and a dedicated duct, and that single decision drives the fit-out cost, the lease negotiation and the layout. Under-specify it and the room smells of yesterday.

Floor Plan — 40-Seat Korean BBQ (10 grill tables · 300 sq ft kitchen)



Flow: 4 Four dolsot burners for stews and bibimbap · 5 Range, fryer and the meat slicer · 6 Ten grill tables, each with its own duct · Banchan and soju stations at the room edge for fast refills

GRILL TABLES AND EXTRACTION

Ten tables, each with a gas or charcoal grill well and a dedicated downdraft or overhead duct at \$2,000–4,500 per table installed — the largest line in the fit-out and the one that cannot be value-engineered. Weak extraction means the room, the upholstery and the guests' clothes hold smoke, which is the most common fatal error in a new Korean BBQ. Treat grates as a consumable: three or four spares per table, pre-heated, swapped every two to three orders.

MEAT SLICER

A commercial slicer is not optional. Chadolbaegi at 1–2mm and bulgogi at 3–4mm are specifications a knife cannot hold at volume, and the partial-freeze routine — two hours in the freezer before slicing — is a daily prep step rather than a trick. Broken down and sanitised nightly, with the calibration checked weekly against a sample slice.

KIMCHI AND FERMENTATION

A dedicated 2°C refrigerator for kimchi at different ages, labelled by date, plus ambient space for the three-day primary ferment. Keeping fresh and aged crocks separate is what lets the kitchen serve geotjeori as banchan and mukimchi into the jjigae, and the labelling is what makes that deliberate rather than accidental. The cheapest asset in the building that appreciates.

BANCHAN AND DOLSOT STATIONS

A cold banchan station at the room's edge holding six to eight prepped bowls in inserts, so a refill is three steps rather than a trip to the kitchen — which is what makes silent replenishment possible at all. Four burners carry the dolsot dishes, and the pots are heated empty until smoking before anything goes in. Twelve to sixteen in rotation, since a stone pot needs real time to cool and cannot be rushed back into service.

EQUIPMENT	SPEC	EST. COST	PRIORITY
Grill tables ×10 with extraction	Gas or charcoal well, dedicated duct	\$20,000–45,000	Must have
Spare grill grates ×40	Rotated every 2–3 orders	\$800–1,600	Must have
Commercial meat slicer	1mm capable, daily calibration	\$2,000–4,500	Must have
Dolsot burners ×4 · stone pots ×16	High-BTU, open flame	\$1,800–3,600	Must have
Kimchi refrigerator	2°C, dedicated, date-labelled	\$1,500–3,000	Must have
Fryer, 2-basket	Dakgangjeong double fry, yakgwa	\$1,200–2,400	Must have
Shaved ice machine	Block-ice capable, for bingsu	\$200–400	High
Cold banchan station	8 inserts, room-edge sited	\$1,400–2,800	Must have
Range and walk-in	4 burners; 2°C walk-in	\$8,000–14,000	Must have
Table scissors and tongs ×20 sets	Dedicated BBQ service	\$200–400	Must have
Total Estimate		\$37,100–77,700	New build

Nunchi — Reading the Table

Nunchi is the Korean word for the ability to read a room, and it is the invisible standard that separates a good Korean BBQ from a great one. Practically it means the floor is watching three things constantly: banchan levels, grate condition, and whether the table knows what to do with what is in front of them.

ARRIVAL AND THE FIRST GRILL

"Welcome — the banchan are on us and we'll keep them coming, so just eat through them. Have you done Korean BBQ before? If not I'll get the first round started for you and show you the wrap." Cooking the first round for a first-time table is the single highest-value service act in this format: it sets the doneness standard, prevents the burnt first batch that sours a meal, and gives permission to take over afterwards.

GRATE AND BANCHAN DISCIPLINE

Swap the grate before the guest notices it is dark; refill a banchan bowl before it is empty. Asking "would you like more kimchi?" is acceptable and silently replacing the bowl is the standard. Both are the same skill: scanning every table on every pass rather than waiting to be signalled.

TEACHING THE SSAM

"Take a perilla leaf, piece of meat, a little ssamjang, a grilled garlic clove, fold it and eat it in one bite. And try a bite of the grilled kimchi with the pork — that's the classic pairing." Two sentences, and the guest now has a technique they will use for the rest of their life and repeat to whoever they bring next time.

THE NAENGMYEON CLOSE

"A lot of people finish with the cold noodles after the grill — icy broth, very refreshing after all that. Would you like one to share?" Offered at the right moment, when the table is feeling the richness, this converts unusually well and adds a \$16.99 item to a check that had already peaked. Then sikhye, which is how the meal is meant to end.

Prep Schedule and Hold Times

ITEM	BATCH	FREQUENCY	HOLD	CRITICAL RULE
Baechu kimchi	5kg napa	Weekly	Months, improving	3 days at 18–20°C to pH 4.2–4.5, then 2°C
Anchovy-kelp dashi	5L	Daily	2 days chilled	Kelp out before the boil
Bulgogi and galbi marinade	Per 5kg meat	Daily	Meat: 12h / 24h max	Pear enzymes keep working — respect the ceiling
Meat slicing	Day's forecast	Daily	Same service	Partial-freeze 2 hours; 1–2mm brisket, 3–4mm bulgogi
Banchan, six dishes	40 portions	Daily	Namul 2 days, japchae 4	Namul seasoned assertively; japchae components cooked separately
Ssamjang	1kg	Weekly	2 weeks chilled	60:25 doenjang to gochujang
Galbi jjim	10–12 portions	Thu + Fri	3 days chilled	Blanch first; skim the set fat next morning
Dongchimi broth	5L	Weekly	2 weeks at 2°C	Served at 2°C over ice, never tepid
Yakgwa	80 cookies	Monday	1 week, improving	Fried 150°C, soaked 30 min in warm syrup
Milk ice blocks	20 × 500ml	Twice weekly	2 weeks frozen	Shaved to order; never pre-plated
Grill grates	40 in rotation	Continuous	—	Pre-heated spares; swap every 2–3 orders

Group Bookings and the Numbers

Korean BBQ retains guests better than almost any format because the meal is participatory — people remember an evening they took part in, not just food they were served. Commercially that shows up as group bookings, which is where this room makes its money.

GROUPS OF SIX AND OVER

Two grill tables joined, a set meat selection at a fixed per-head price, banchan replenished continuously, soju by the bottle. Groups spend more per head than pairs and they book ahead, which is what smooths a Tuesday. Take deposits on parties over eight and hold the tables at the room's edge where extraction is strongest.

THE LUNCH SET

A kitchen-only lunch — bibimbap, jjigae, japchae, no grill — at \$18–22 with banchan and rice, out in twelve minutes. It uses the stations the grills do not touch, needs no extra staff, and turns an empty midday room into revenue without diluting the dinner offer.

COST CATEGORY	% REVENUE	NOTES
Food cost	22%	Grill items run 16–24%; banchan adds ~\$2.24 per table on top
Beverage cost	18%	Soju and beer volume is the highest-attach drinks programme in the series
Kitchen labour	15%	Prep-heavy rather than service-heavy — most of the work is done by 4pm
Front of house labour	13%	Higher than a plated room: grate swaps, banchan refills, first-round grilling
Rent	10%	Needs ceiling height and ductwork — narrows the site search
Utilities	6%	Ten table grills plus extraction running four hours a night
Grates, consumables, maintenance	3%	Grates are a consumable; duct cleaning is quarterly and non-negotiable
Marketing and misc	3%	Cheese pull and grill content is largely organic
Total Costs	90%	
Net Profit	10%	At \$55–80 per head, on a 40-seat room turning twice

WHERE THIS FORMAT WINS AND LOSES

It wins on check size: \$55–80 a head is the highest in the series, driven by meat plus soju plus the participatory length of the meal. It loses on utilities and front-of-house labour, both structurally higher than a plated restaurant, and on fit-out, where ten ducted grill tables can absorb \$45,000 before a single pan is

bought. The controllable lines are grate discipline, which protects the food, and beverage attach, which is where the margin actually comes from. Watch the beef price weekly; brisket and short rib are the only volatile inputs.

Allergen Summary — All 28 Items

[illegible]

ITEM	GLUTEN	SOY	SESAME	FISH	SHELL	EGGS	DAIRY	PEANUT	GF	VEGAN
Boricha	●	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	●
Watermelon Soju	●	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	●	●

● Contains · ● Optional or substitutable · — Not present. Four things need declaring proactively here. Soy is in almost everything — soy sauce, doenjang, gochujang, tofu — so a soy allergy makes most of this menu unavailable rather than adjustable, and that must be said plainly. Fish sauce in the kimchi means the kimchi, and therefore the standard banchan set and the kimchi jjigae, are not vegetarian; a ganjang-only kimchi is the fix and should be batched separately if vegetarian trade is meaningful. Anchovy-kelp dashi puts fish into every stew including the tofu one, which surprises guests who order sundubu as a vegetarian dish. Sesame is pervasive and structural rather than a garnish. Gochujang and doenjang are commonly made with wheat, so a gluten-free guest needs the brand checked rather than assumed; tamari and certified GF pastes make bibimbap, japchae and most grill items workable. Peanut appears in dakgangjeong only. Barley in boricha and most lagers is the gluten in the drinks list.

The Grill Is a Stage

Korean BBQ is not a meal, it is an event, and every operational decision in this guide follows from that. The table grill is a stage, the banchan are the opening act, and the meat is the performance. Which means the guest is not a recipient here — they are a participant, cooking, wrapping, pouring for each other, arguing about somaek ratios. That participation is why this format retains customers better than almost any other: people remember evenings they took part in far longer than meals they were served.

The technical spine is fermentation, and it is the rare kitchen asset that appreciates. House kimchi at three days is one product and at three weeks it is another, and the second one is a required ingredient rather than waste — which means the kimchi jjigae is measurably better in month six than in week one. Aged doenjang, maesil syrup drawn off after a hundred days, yakgwa that improves across the week it sits: this is a cuisine that rewards patience with flavour that cannot be bought in.

The two places to spend are extraction and the slicer. Under-specified ducting is the most common fatal error in a new Korean BBQ, because a room that holds smoke cannot be fixed after opening and every guest carries the evidence home on their clothes. And a commercial slicer is what makes chadolbaegi at 1mm and bulgogi at 3mm possible at all — those thicknesses are the dishes, not preferences about them.

Everything else is nunchi: swapping a grate before the guest sees it darken, refilling a banchan bowl before it is empty, cooking a first-timer's opening round so their meal does not start with burnt meat, offering the cold noodles at the exact moment richness fatigue arrives. None of that appears on a recipe card and all of it is the difference between a good Korean BBQ and one people book a month out.

The technique is in this guide. The nunchi is yours to develop, one service at a time.